

אֲשֶׁר צִוָּה ה' לֵאמֹר דִּבֶּר אֶל בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל וַיִּקְחוּ אֵלֶיךָ פָּרָה אֲדֹמָה תְּמִימָה, פֶּרֶשֶׁת חֻקַּת. So the mitzva has the unusual לִשְׁוֹן of וַיִּקְחוּ אֵלֶיךָ. Rashi immediately brings down a מִדְרַש רַבָּה. Why did it have to say וַיִּקְחוּ אֵלֶיךָ, bring to you a פָּרָה אֲדֹמָה? It's a פָּרָה אֲדֹמָה for anybody who is טָמֵא. What purpose is served by saying that it has to be brought to you, to מֹשֶׁה רַבֵּינוּ?

The מִדְרַש רַבָּה says, לְעוֹלָם הִיא נִקְרָאת עַל שְׁמֵךְ פָּרָה שֶׁעָשָׂה מֹשֶׁה בְּמִדְבָּר, Throughout all generations, for all time, the פָּרָה אֲדֹמָה will be called in Moshe's name. What is Rashi saying here? It's brought down from the Torah Treasures that the אַרִיז"ל says that a person who does not understand the deeper meaning of his תְּפִילוֹת should meditate on infusing them with all of the intentions of the אֲנָשִׁי כִנְסַת הַגְּדוּלָה who composed the תְּפִילוֹת, what they had in mind. The חֲכָמִים tell us that מֹשֶׁה was the only person in the entire history of the world to whom Hashem revealed the rationale of the פָּרָה אֲדֹמָה.

When the people of Yisroel would later prepare other אֲדֹמוֹת, פָּרָה אֲדֹמוֹת, all they could possibly say when they're doing it is that they have in mind to invest in them the כּוּוֹנוֹת and the fundamental meaning that Moshe had when he made the first אֲדֹמָה. That is what Rashi is saying. The פָּרָה אֲדֹמָה will always be named after Moshe because we're always going to have to depend on his כּוּוֹנוֹת, the intentions that Moshe had when he had prepared the first פָּרָה in the מִדְבָּר. This leads me to a fascinating story from the Lubavitcher חֲסִידוֹת literature, which I'd like to share with you. It's rather long, but you will see at the end that it's extraordinarily worthwhile.

During the time of the אֶלְטֵעַ Rebbe, who was Rebbe זְלַמֵּן שְׁנִיאָוֹר from Liadi, who was the founder of חֲב"ד chasidus, a law was passed that forcibly moved the Jews from rural villages to larger towns. They had to leave where they lived and congregate in bigger towns. This particularly harsh decree left many Jews destitute, they had no פֶּרֶסָה. A great deal of money was required to alleviate their plight. Not only were many poor families without basic necessities, but they had to bribe officials to leave the Jews alone.

To this end, the אֶלְטֵעַ Rebbe began traveling extensively through the region asking people for donations. On one such mission, it took him to the town of Bolin, near the city of Tulchin, where ר' בְּרוּךְ, the בַּעַל שֵׁם'ס grandson resided. The אֶלְטֵעַ Rebbe decided to pay ר' בְּרוּךְ a visit. ר' בְּרוּךְ was delighted by this honor.

"What brings you here?" ר' בְּרוּךְ asked. "Well," the אֶלְטֵעַ Rebbe replied, "I am raising funds to bribe government officials to leave the Yidden alone. The pitiful plight of my brethren is too much to bear." ר' בְּרוּךְ was surprised. "Surely, you could have averted this decree by using your רִוְחָנִיּוּת, spirituality. Why are you actually going around collecting money? You could have davened and could have averted the decree." The אֶלְטֵעַ Rebbe elucidated, "I am only following a precedent. When יַעֲקֹב אַבִּינוּ was in danger, no doubt he could have used his זְכוּתִים to alleviate the harsh decree without having to placate his brother with gifts and bribes. But you see, he declared, 'I'm sending a present to אֲדֹנִי עֲשׂוּ.' And that's how he was appeased."

ר' בְּרוּךְ remained unconvinced. The אֶלְטֵעַ Rebbe was a great צַדִּיק. Why would he have to lower himself to act in this way, shlepping from place to place to collect צְדָקָה? "But why didn't you just teach them the meaning of the word אָחָד according to the שֵׁם טוֹב'ס teaching? The decree would have then been automatically nullified." "It was precisely your grandfather's אָחָד that caused this whole problem in the first place!" the אֶלְטֵעַ Rebbe replied. He then revealed the following fascinating story. After the Jews were expelled from Spain in 1492, not one country was willing to take them in. The reason for this, as with everything else, came from the upper spheres, the מַלְאָכִים. In שָׁמַיִם, the מַלְאָכִי שֶׁרָת representing the various nations were arguing amongst themselves, "We don't want the Jews in our land. The first thing they'll do is build shuls and they'll build a מִדְרַש, and they'll daven and they'll learn. We don't want them to say ה' אָחָד." The מַלְאָכִים were afraid that this declaration of הוּא בְּרוּךְ'ס unity would nullify their very



existence. This spiritual reality was reflected down below. The leaders of each nation refused to take in the Jews. There was only one מלאך who was not afraid, the מלאך השרת of Poland. In fact, he saw this as a golden opportunity to increase his own impure כח.

“They don’t scare me,” he declared, “I’ll take them in. It’ll be to my advantage. It is true they will build ישיבות, and it’s true they will study תורה and they will say ה’ אחד, but they will not have the proper כוונה, and I will get stronger.” And so it came to pass. The king of Poland agreed to accept the bribe, a pile of money as high as a mounted cossack holding a spear standing up.

Indeed, the Jews arrived in Poland in droves. They built shuls, they built בתי מדרש, established businesses, they learned תורה, and they said ה’ אלקינו ה’ אחד. And as the ministering angel had predicted, they did not have the proper כוונה.

The מלאך was delighted, his plan was working. His own powers were increasing day to day. Unfortunately for him, the בעל שם טוב came along. The בעל שם טוב came along and taught the Jews a dimension of אחד that was entirely different.

He gave them the correct כוונה. “That’s not fair!” the מלאך of Poland cried. “The deal is off. The deal is null and void. I only agreed to accept them under the terms of the old אחד, not this new one.” Down on earth, the Jews were going to be kicked out, have to find another home. The noose was tightened around the throat of European Jewry. Many Jews were expelled from their villages.

“Now do you understand?” the אלטע Rebbe concluded. “The new law is a direct result of your grandfather’s אחד. That is why money is once again needed to avert the harsh decree.”

Having read this story, I approached Rabbi Oelbuam and I said, “What is the proper כוונה for אחד?” He replied, “What do you think?” I said, “קבלת עול מלכות שמים” which is, of course, a very proper כוונה. My second כוונה is מסירות נפש for שמירת שמים. The third כוונה which I had said until that point was to be מקיים the מצוה of וערבת עמך.

Rabbi Oelbuam told me, “What you should add on is that I should have the כל הקדמונים בהם שכיוונו כוונה. That is the כוונה of the אלטע Rebbe. That I should have a כוונה to be מקיים the הקדמונים בהם שכיוונו כוונה.” That is the כוונה I have when I say שמע.

You can follow it or not follow it. You can hear what I have to say or not. But that’s a good answer. When I said to you that they brought the פרה אדומה אליך, משה רבינו, that all דורות will not have the proper כוונה for the פרה אדומה. That’s why it’s called of משה רבינו, that’s why it says וַיִּקְחוּ אֵלָיָהּ. We will depend on the כוונה of משה רבינו. He understood what the מצוה of פרה אדומה was and what it represented. We have no clue because for us it’s a חוק. So in exactly the same way as the אלטע Rebbe and the בעל שם actually taught the people the כוונה for אחד, משה רבינו had the כוונה for the פרה אדומה and we depend on his כוונה to fulfill the מצוה of פרה אדומה, which we hope will come back very soon, אמן במהרה בימינו.

